# Teaching Statement

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## 1. Approach to Teaching

At UVA, my teaching experience includes introductory and intermediate microeconomics and macroeconomics, finance, and the economics of risk and uncertainty. My goal is to help students develop their economic reasoning by having them ask and answer questions. Through a Socratic-style exchange of ideas, I encourage students to share different viewpoints while preserving the mathematical rigor essential to understanding economics. I have applied this approach in every class I have taught, most notably as an independent instructor for Intermediate Macroeconomics. But speaking up in a theory course is harder than it sounds. Making this inquiry-driven method work means helping students overcome three barriers: How do I form a question about something I don't understand? Will I be judged if I guess wrong? And why should I care about abstract theory?

## 2. Classroom Practice and Student Comments

To help students form questions about unfamiliar material, I slow down the derivation and illustrate the inquiry process myself. The paradox is that students who do not yet understand a model may not know what to ask, especially when they first encounter dynamic models with a system of endogenous variables. I use the blackboard to derive models step by step instead of presenting completed results, making it easy for students to stop me at their exact point of confusion. I approach the model from a student's perspective, asking the questions someone encountering the material for the first time might ask. Over time, students apply this approach to their own studies.

> *"He was a great lecturer and was really good at breaking down complex topics and slowing down when people asked him to."*

To alleviate the pressure of being judged for speaking up, I welcome every tentative response as a valuable contribution that drives the lecture forward. I treat incomplete answers as part of the reasoning process rather than as errors to be corrected, drawing out the economic point in a student's comment and connecting it to the lecture's framework. I may say, "You are hinting at another model that is also common in the literature," or "Your concern is valid in practice, but in this simplified setting we assume it away." Watching their own words shape the discussion encourages students to speak up again, and each question becomes a public good the whole room can build on.

> *"Zitian was always open to hearing from everyone, and he was extremely gentle and encouraging even if someone gave a response that was a little off the mark. Zitian nurtured our learning by redirecting student's answers, inevitably allowing more to contribute in the future. There was never any sense of pressure for giving a 'wrong' answer, as Zitian created an open and supportive environment."*

To give students a reason to care about abstract theory, I show them how individual decisions drive aggregate macroeconomic outcomes, drawing on my research in game theory and experiments. In the final part of the course, I introduced best responses and equilibrium to analyze a bank run as a coordination problem, a topic rarely taught in undergraduate macroeconomics. By analyzing

the coexistence of run and no-run equilibria, students saw how strategic uncertainty about other depositors' actions can generate a crisis, and because equilibrium selection depends on confidence, why that crisis is hard to predict. I also invited students to participate in laboratory experiments on asset markets, consumer search, and bounded rationality, and almost the entire class took part. Connecting abstract theory to financial crises and live experiments gave students with different goals a shared reason to engage. Class attendance stayed high, usually around 25 of my 29 students.

> *". . . you get to look under the hood of what drives our economy. It's refreshing to see the mathematics that drive certain economic factors, rather than just learning a shallow layer."*

My finance teaching connects theory with computational problem-solving. As a teaching assistant for Global Financial Markets, I explain general equilibrium models with financial assets and help students use MATLAB to solve them. I also work with the professor to develop coding-based exam questions that require students to apply and interpret the models they have learned.

### 3. Mentoring, Advising, and Service

Beyond the classroom, I tailor my support to each student's academic and career goals. I have written recommendations for transfer applications, industry opportunities, and teaching-assistant positions. One student secured a place on a UVA-affiliated industry project arranged through Riipen. Another became a teaching assistant and began teaching lower-year students, a meaningful way for me to pass the torch. For students interested in research, I suggest papers on topics they want to explore. I also advise students on graduate school applications and careers in finance and technology. In the experimental economics laboratory, I mentor undergraduate assistants as they progress from assisting with sessions to running experiments independently. I also organize UVA's Theory/Experimental Economics Student Workshop and Reading Group.

> *"I often came to office hours with plenty of questions to ask. Zitian took his time to explain the things that were confusing me . . . I was able to succeed and improve my performance because my professor wanted to take the time to see me grow."*

### 4. Student Evaluation Scores

Intermediate Macroeconomics, Spring 2026, as an independent instructor. Scores are out of 5.

| | **Mine** | **Department** |
|---|---|---|
| Overall, the instructor was an effective teacher | 4.65 | 4.30 |
| Provided opportunities for my active participation | 4.47 | 4.21 |
| Respected difference and welcomed diverse perspectives | 4.47 | 4.16 |
| Fostered an environment where I felt valued and belonged | 4.53 | 4.26 |
| Was available to help support my learning | 4.65 | 4.33 |
| Provided me prompt and useful feedback on my learning | 4.41 | 4.08 |